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Petroniana
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Petroniana

1. *linguam caninam comedi* (43.3)

Phileros' strange phrase *linguam caninam comedi* (43.3 : *de re tamen ego uerum dicam, qui linguam caninam comedi*) has so far eluded all attempts at interpretation. None of the five proposals recorded by Smith is compelling ([1]), and one of them is based on a misunderstanding that should be corrected.

M. Pokrovskij, in a brief communication on *Pétrone et le folklore russe* ([2]), suggested that *linguam caninam comedi* may reflect a folk expression similar to the Russian locution *ja v ètom dele sobaku s"el* ([3]), literally "in that matter, I've eaten a dog", comparing further the related verb *nasobačit'sja*, which is transparently based on the word for "dog" (*sobaka*). Unfortunately, however, Pokrovskij, writing in French, rendered the meaning of the expression via the misleading translation "je connais cette affaire à fond" ; this translation, reproduced by Perrochat ([4]), was naturally interpreted by Smith (*loc. cit.*) to mean "I know the matter thoroughly". With this sort of meaning, such an expression would indeed seem applicable to what Phileros may be saying : he will tell the truth, since he is fully knowledgeable about the situation. But in point of fact, the Russian expression means nothing of the kind. It means "connaître une affaire à fond" only in the restricted sense of having skill or expertise at doing something, and cannot refer to something like having knowledge of (or being informed about) a situation. This is eminently clear from the related verb *nasobačit'sja*, which Pokrovskij unambiguously glossed as "devenir expert" (perhaps better rendered as "maîtriser") – a form which both Perrochat and Smith fail to mention. Given, then, a correct understanding of the Russian expression, the comparison with *linguam caninam comedi* is considerably less appealing than Perrochat and Smith make it out to be. For Phileros' phrase to make any sense in terms of the Russian expression, we must be told what sort of skill Phileros is claiming for himself (e.g., the skill of evaluating people's "real" personalities), or else we must assume that the variant *linguam caninam comedi* (instead of simply *canem*

(1) Martin S. SMITH, *Petronii Arbitri Cena Trimalchionis*, Oxford, 1975, p. 103, ad loc.

(2) *Comptes Rendus de l'Académie des Sciences de l'URSS* (= Doklady Akademii Nauk SSSR) 1930, series B, p. 85-7.

(3) Also currently usable with *na (na ètom)*, and recorded earlier with the accusative (*na èto*) ; see e.g. Vladimir DAL', *Tolkovyj slovar' živogo velikorusskogo jazyka*, St. Petersburg-Moscow, 1880[2], vol. IV, p. 251.

(4) P. PERROCHAT, *Le festin de Trimalchion*, Paris, 1962[3], p. 53.

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comedi) supplies this information : "I'll tell the truth, since I've eaten a dog's *tongue*" (= "I'm good at *talking*"). But even if we can extract some sense from what Phileros says via a plausible typological parallel of this kind, there remains the fundamental problem that such a folk expression — which in this case cannot be assumed to be universal — is nowhere attested in Latin.

Friedlaender's suggestion that what Phileros says reflects an otherwise undocumented popular superstition to the effect that eating a dog's tongue causes one to speak the truth ([5]) suffers from the same difficulty. But there are two attractive premises common to both Pokrovskij's and Friedlaender's proposals : first, that Phileros' phrase somehow contains indigenous "folkish" material, as would be eminently suitable to the verbal behavior of Phileros and his *colliberti* ; and second, that the material would be sufficiently "popular" to be readily understood not only by Phileros' immediate audience, but by Petronius' more sophisticated one. None of the other explanations proposed fulfills both of these criteria, which would seem to be necessary for a proper solution to the interpretation of Phileros' phrase.

The popular discourse characteristic of the freedmen's speech includes a number of references to superstitious beliefs, partly couched in allusive language. Such beliefs, moreover, are often encoded in the form of proverbs or proverbial expressions, which are again highly characteristic of the language of the freedmen ([6]). It is also noteworthy that Phileros' language is permeated, to a degree remarkable even for one of Trimalchio's *colliberti*, with "colorful" locutions of all kinds, many of which have a proverbial ring (and many of which, like *linguam caninam comedi*, pose interpretive, and sometimes textual, difficulties) ([7]). An additional feature favoring a proverb (as opposed, say, to localized wives' tales) is that such expressions would normally be comprehensible to Petronius' elite audience, even if our remoteness in time and space renders some of them obscure to us. For these reasons, a solution in terms of a well-known proverb should be highly favored, although Phileros' first-person phrasing here (as well as his discourse-style in general) may allow us to suspect some *alteration* of proverbial material.

An ancient and well-known Roman proverb concerning the eating of dog flesh — and the only such proverb recorded — seems never to have been noted in this connection ; it is cited by Varro at *L.L.* 7.31, in the form *canis caninam non est* ([8]).

(5) L. FRIEDLAENDER, *Petronii Cena Trimalchionis*, Leipzig, 1906², p. 254.

(6) See the listing by D. ALTAMURA, *Proverbia locutionesque populares apud Petronium* in *Latinitas* 22 (1974), p. 181-96 ; for *linguam caninam comedere* (p. 183), Altamura simply provides a contextual gloss "liberam vocem mittere", without commentary.

(7) E.g. *honeste uixit, honeste obiit* and *paratus fuit quadrantem de stercore mordicus tollere* (43.1), *creuit quicquid tetigit tamquam fauus* (43.2), *malam parram pilauit* (43.4), *longe fugit, quisquis suos fugit* (43.5), *qui cito credit* (43.6), *cui datum est, non cui destinatum* (43.7), etc.

(8) On this proverb, see A. OTTO, *Die Sprichwörter und sprichwörtlichen Redensarten der Römer*, Leipzig, 1890, p. 70, with parallels from Greek and elsewhere. The ellipsis of *carnem* in such expressions is normal, and the use of adjective (as opposed to possessive genitive)

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Of particular importance is Varro's further reference to the same proverb at *R.R.* 2.9.9, where the manner of Varro's allusion to the proverb (which he explicitly labels a *prouerbium anticum*, and which he refers to obliquely, without feeling a need to cite it) clearly indicates how familiar the saying must have been ([9]). I suggest, then, that when Phileros claims to have eaten a dog's tongue (*linguam caninam comedi*), he is somehow referring to this ancient and obviously well-known lore about dogs not eating the flesh of other dogs (*canis caninam non est*).

Like so much of what Phileros says, the precise interpretation remains unclear. Given the tenor of his speech, however, we may guess that the use of *canis* as a term of abuse is somehow relevant (cf. Fortunata's ultimate insult to Trimalchio at 74.10, and the references cited by Smith, ad loc.). There has clearly been bad blood between Phileros and Chrysanthus ; Phileros not only refuses to eulogize him (following Seleucus' maudlin commentary on Chrysanthus' funeral), but insists on setting the record straight about him (43.1) : *ille habet quod debebatur : honeste uixit, honeste obiit. Quid habet quod queratur ?* With obvious pique and jealousy, Phileros goes on to chronicle (43.1-2) Chrysanthus' Horatio Alger story (*ab asse creuit*), his money-grubbing nature (*paratus fuit quadrantem de stercore mordicus tollere*), and the extent of his fortune (*puto mehercules illum reliquisse solida centum, et omnia in nummis habuit*). He continues with a bitter catalogue of Chrysanthus' vices, which he prefaces (43.3) with the words *De re tamen ego uerum dicam, qui linguam caninam comedi.* Perhaps Phileros visualizes his former relationship with Chrysanthus in what we might call "dog-eat-dog" terms : as freedmen, despite Chrysanthus' financial success, they were both basically a couple of "dogs" (Phileros may be implying) ; but Phileros — in contrast to what the proverb says — has "eaten" the dog's tongue (i.e. turned against one of his own kind), and will now tell the truth about Chrysanthus. It is of course possible that this altered version is based on a variant of the proverb that happens not to be attested ; but more likely this is Phileros' own (comical ?) adaptation of the proverb, with *linguam* loosely and ludicrously substituted for *carnem*, either with reference to his own intention to speak the truth, or to Chrysanthus' own vicious speech habits — the very thing Phileros proceeds to criticize : *durae buccae fuit, linguosus.*

parallels the similar usage in phrases like *lingua canina* ; see Hubert PETERSMANN, *Petrons urbane Prosa : Untersuchungen zu Sprache und Text (Syntax)*, Vienna, 1977, p. 69-70.

(9) In warning about the consequences of not providing dogs with a sufficient supply of food, Varro says, *Fames enim hos ad quaerendum cibum ducet, si non praebebitur, et a pecore abducet ; nisi si, ut quidam putant, etiam illuc peruenerint, prouerbium ut tollant anticum uel etiam ut μῦθον aperiant de Actaeone atque in dominum adferant dentes.* Thus "even if they do not, as some people think, go so far as to disprove the old proverb" clearly refers to the saying *canis caninam non est.* Rather strikingly, the "old proverb" is apparently self-evident (and thus not further explained), but the *μῦθος* about Actaeon requires some explanation.

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2. *et <ei> qui* (58.7)

Hermeros ([10]) concludes part of his tirade against Giton with the following threat (printed as in H, with the exception of Heinsius' universally accepted *Athana* for the *sathana* of H) : *Athana tibi irata sit, curabo, et qui te primus deuro de fecit* (58.7). Grammar and sense, however, seem to demand a dative antecedent for *qui*, whence Reinesius' (paleographically easy) conjecture *et < ei > qui* ; cf. also the parallel *curabo, iam tibi Iouis iratus sit, et isti qui tibi non imperat* (58.2), near the beginning of the same speech. Although the conjecture is ignored by most earlier editors, both Müller[2] and Smith, for example, print *et < ei > qui*.

But the pronoun is quite unnecessary, and this "improvement" of the text is therefore to be rejected, no matter how plausible it may be paleographically. The omission of an oblique-case antecedent of a relative pronoun is not only admissible, but idiomatic : attested with certainty at all periods of the language, it is particularly frequent in both Archaic Latin and in informal contexts, justifying its characterization as "speziell umgangssprachlich" ([11]). Especially after the explicit *isti* in the parallel phrase already mentioned, pronominal specification in the phrase's second occurrence is simply otiose in Hermeros' speech style. The reading of H, then, is linguistically (or rather, sociolinguistically) precise, and should not be emended.

3. *† semper flauius †* (133.3)

Encolpius, in his prayer to Priapus, invokes the divinity as follows :

> *Nympharum Bacchique comes, quem pulchra Dione*
> *diuitibus siluis numen dedit, inclita paret*
> *cui Lesbos uiridisque Thasos, quem Lydus adorat*
> *† semper flauius † templumque suis imponit Hypaepis :*
> *huc ades ...*

Both representatives of the O-tradition begin the fourth line with *semper*, although they agree neither on word-division nor on the form following *semper* : B *sep flauius* (i.e. *semper flauius*), R *semperfluus* ; nearly all other manuscripts read *septifluus* ([12]), for which some editors naturally opt, given the unmetrical O-tradition readings.

The meaning of *septifluus*, however, is exceedingly difficult to interpret. The adjective type in X-*fluus* was indeed relatively productive (see Ernout-Meillet, *Dict.* s.v. *fluo*) ; but it remains unclear just what a form like *septifluus* would have meant. Even if *Lydus septifluus* means "le Lydien aux sept fleuves" (Ernout, cf. Sullivan's

(10) Or so the speaker is conventionally designated ; see SMITH, *op. cit.*, p. 154, ad 57.1.

(11) So e.g. J. B. HOFMANN (-Anton SZANTYR), *Lateinische Syntax und Stilistik* (Munich, 1972), p. 555 ; see p. 555-6 for an overview of the history of this construction in Latin, with selected examples and bibliography.

(12) The *septiflicus* of F is easily explained on the basis of *septifluus*.

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"the Lydians spread over the seven rivers", Penguin[2]), it is surprising that Petronius would choose such a bizarre designation for Lydia or a Lydian, since Encolpius needs to invoke the divinity using clear and respectful terminology, as he does with the other adjective-noun combinations he uses : *pulchra Dione, diuitibus siluis, inclita Lesbos, uiridis Thasos.* Nor is Alessio's interpretation of *septifluus* convincing in the least : "qui septies ad terram fuit [sc. ceruicem]», comparing Virgil, *G.* 3.24 *ad terramque fluit ceruix*, and more generally the practice of "adorazione" (cf. *adorat*) via bowing the head, documented for various peoples of Asia Minor (and, of course, elsewhere) ([13]). Note first that Alessio's gloss of *septifluus* is unacceptable, since *fluo* in this usage is intransitive, as the Virgil passage shows ; but even in the unlikely event that the form means something like "seven-bowing", i.e. "with [head/neck] drooping/bowing seven [times]", it is almost inconceivable that Petronius would concoct, in this context, such an arcane designation for a Lydian – one based, moreover, on a rare and highly metaphorical usage of *fluo* that otherwise has no discernible association with religious devotion.

Turnebus' emendation *uestifluus* "with flowing garments" is certainly interpretable, and may well be appropriate for a Lydian, but it is not paleographically attractive. Bücheler's *semper ouans* is also paleographically difficult, and raises, moreover, the question of whether one word or two is to be conjectured. For this point the reading *semperfluus* of R, beside the L-tradition *septifluus* (vs. the *semper flauius* of B) seems significant. Once an initial sequence containing either *sep-* or something like it was misread or misinterpreted as *semper*, a scribe might naturally separate *semper* from the remaining material ; and if this was *-fluus*, we can also easily imagine this being converted into a recognizable self-standing word like *flauius*. But R's rather striking *semperfluus* is better explained as a conservative retention of what was originally a single word than as a univerbation : the scribe chose not to take a second step (*-fluus* to e.g. *flauius*), and maintained the word-division he found ([14]). The simplest hypothesis, then, is that the text had a single word ending in *-fluus*, and beginning with *sep-* or something very much like it.

I would suggest, then, that Reiske's *sertifluus* "with flowing/luxuriant garlands" (or "luxuriant with garlands") has been unduly neglected, and is almost certainly correct. Apart from the appropriateness of the meaning (cf. Müller's apt comment "exspectes *sacrificus*", and see further below), this conjecture accords very well with

(13) Giovanni ALESSIO, *'Hapax legomena' ed altre 'cruces' in Petronio*, Naples, 1960-61, p. 318-19.

(14) An interesting parallel occurs at 131.8 (also a hexameter poem) : at the end of the sixth line, R and P (within the O-tradition) and L all preserve a correct word-division, as against B (the oldest witness of the O-tradition), but no manuscript records the true reading : RP *siluester iasdon* (cf. lr *siluestris hirundo*) vs. B *siluesterisdon*, the true reading being *siluester aëdon* (Pius). Here, of course, the situation is reversed, in that B shows univerbation of an original two-word phrase, while RP and the L-tradition have correctly maintained two separate words ; but the pattern of preservation is the same.

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the paleographic considerations just discussed, in terms of both corruption to *septifluus*, and to something interpretable as an abbreviation of *semper*. Further support comes from the use of *serta* "garlands" in pre-Augustan and Augustan poetry.

Perhaps the most familiar appearance of *serta* is on the heads of lovers, particularly in the context of the *exclusus amator*, as attested in Lucretius' famous description (4.1177-8 *at lacrimans exclusus amator limina saepe | floribus et sertis operit*), and throughout Augustan elegy ([15]). Apart from the recurring adjectives emphasizing the elegance, prettiness, or even effeminacy of the *serta* (*florida/florea, odorata, mollia*, etc.), a specifically Eastern association is sometimes made more explicit (e.g. Catullus 6.8, *sertis ac Syrio fragrans oliuo*). When Lucretius rails, in book 4, against the conversion of wealth (in the context of the evils of successful love) into various types of Eastern finery (tapestries, slippers from Sicyon, robes from Alinda or Ceos), he concludes with the following list (4.1131-2) :

> *eximia ueste et uictu conuiuia, ludi,*
> *pocula crebra, unguenta, coronae, serta parantur.*

The contrasting passage on the *exclusus amator* and the problems of unrequited love, where *serta* again make an appearance (as mentioned above), follows directly. The erotic (and partly Eastern) associations of *serta* are not, however, the whole story. Almost equally prominent (and nearly as frequent in Tibullus, for example, as the erotic usage) is the appearance of *serta* in contexts of religious devotion : *serta* are placed on an altar or offered to a divinity (e.g. Tibullus 1.1.12, 1.10.22, 1.2.84).

These considerations provide important support for the phrase *Lydus sertifluus* in Petronius. Most telling, however, is a passage that shows *serta* associated not merely with the East, or with ritual practice in general, but with Eastern worship, in a context whose resemblance to the Petronius passage is striking in several respects :

> *ipsa Paphum sublimis abit sedesque reuisit*
> *laeta suas, ubi templum illi, centumque Sabaeo*
> *ture calent arae sertisque recentibus halant* (Virgil, *A.* 1.415-17).

The reference is to Venus, cf. *pulchra Dione* at Petr. 133.3, and *Dione* = *Venus* at Petr. 124, line 266. In addition to the parallel evocations of Aegean place-names as seats of worship (including the phonetically similar *Paphos* and *Thasos*), Petronius' *< sertifluus > templumque* echoes Virgil's *templum illi, centumque ... sertis*.

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(15) Cf. TIBULLUS 1.2.14, and the numerous parallels cited by Kirby Flower SMITH, *The Elegies of Albius Tibullus* [repr. Darmstadt 1971], p. 210, ad loc. For the secondary literature, see especially Paul MURGATROYD, *Tibullus I – A Commentary on the First Book of the Elegies of Albius Tibullus*, Pietermaritzburg, 1980, p. 78.

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